

Committee: United Nations Security Council

Topic: Addressing Disputes over Territorial Sovereignty in Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories

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1. Introduction

Territorial sovereignty remains one of the most important and challenging issues in the Middle East. It refers to the right of a state or people to control a specific territory, including its borders, security, government, and resources. In Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories, conflicts over land and authority have lasted for decades and remain closely linked to disputes, displacement, and regional instability.

In Lebanon, sovereignty disputes mainly focus on the country's southern border with Israel. After Israel withdrew from southern Lebanon in 2000, the United Nations established the Blue Line to confirm the withdrawal. However, the Blue Line is not a final international border, and several areas, including Shebaa Farms, Kfar Shouba Hills, and Ghajar, remain disputed or politically sensitive. These disagreements are made more complex by the presence of Hezbollah in southern Lebanon and Israel's security concerns.

In the Palestinian Territories, the issue of sovereignty is centered on the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and Gaza. Since the 1967 Arab-Israeli War, these territories have been at the center of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Palestinians seek recognition of their right to self-determination and statehood, while Israel argues that security concerns, historical claims, and political realities must be considered. Israeli settlements, border controls, movement restrictions, and the status of Jerusalem remain major obstacles to a lasting peace agreement.

This topic is important for the United Nations Security Council because territorial disputes in Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories directly affect international peace and security. These conflicts have led to repeated violence, humanitarian crises, civilian displacement, and wider tensions across the region. As delegates, the goal is to consider how international law, national sovereignty, security needs, and humanitarian protection can be balanced to reduce conflict and support sustainable political solutions.

2. Definition of Essential Terms

- a) **Territorial Sovereignty:** Territorial sovereignty refers to the right of a state or people to control a specific territory, including its borders, government, security, and national resources. This topic concerns disputes over who has legal and political authority over land in Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories.

- b) **Occupation:** Occupation occurs when one state has effective control over a territory that is not internationally recognized as its own. In the Palestinian context, this term is often used to describe Israel's control over the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and, in different ways, Gaza.
- c) **Self-Determination:** Self-determination is the right of a people to decide their own political status and form of government. For Palestinians, this term is closely linked to the demand for statehood and control over the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and Gaza.
- d) **Blue Line:** The Blue Line is a line established by the United Nations in 2000 to confirm Israel's withdrawal from southern Lebanon. It is not an official international border, but the UN uses it to monitor violations and reduce tensions between Lebanon and Israel.
- e) **Shebaa Farms:** Shebaa Farms is a small disputed area near the borders of Lebanon, Syria, and Israel. Lebanon claims it as Lebanese territory, while Israel has controlled the area since 1967. The dispute remains one of the main territorial issues between Lebanon and Israel.
- f) **Israeli Settlements:** Israeli settlements are communities built by Israeli civilians in territories captured by Israel in 1967, especially in the West Bank and East Jerusalem. Palestinians and much of the international community consider them illegal under international law, while Israel disputes this interpretation.
- g) **UNIFIL:** UNIFIL, the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon, is a UN peacekeeping mission created in 1978. Its role is to monitor the situation in southern Lebanon, support the Lebanese Armed Forces, and help maintain stability along the Blue Line.
- h) **Two-State Solution:** The two-state solution is a proposed peace framework in which Israel and Palestine would exist as two separate states. It is often discussed as a possible solution to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, although disputes over borders, Jerusalem, refugees, settlements, and security remain unresolved.

3. General Context

The disputes over territorial sovereignty in Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories have developed over several decades and are closely connected to the wider Arab-Israeli conflict. In both cases, the central issue is the question of who has the legal and political right to control certain territories. These disputes are not only about borders, but also about security, military presence, displacement, settlements, and the right of people to self-determination.

In Lebanon, the main sovereignty dispute is focused on the southern border with Israel. Israel invaded Lebanon in 1978 and again in 1982, and Israeli forces remained in parts of southern Lebanon for many years. In 2000, Israel withdrew its forces from southern Lebanon. To confirm this withdrawal, the United Nations identified a withdrawal line known as the Blue Line. According to UNIFIL, the Blue Line was established in 2000 to confirm the withdrawal of Israeli forces from Lebanon. However, the Blue Line was not meant to be a permanent or official international border. This is why disagreements over the area have continued.

Several areas near the border remain disputed or politically sensitive, including Shebaa Farms, Kfar Shouba Hills, and Ghajar. Lebanon claims that some of these areas are Lebanese territory, while Israel has controlled parts of them and argues that its security must be protected. These disputes have made it difficult to fully resolve the border issue. They have also contributed to repeated tensions between Israel, Lebanon, and Hezbollah.

Hezbollah is an armed group and political party based in Lebanon. It presents itself as a resistance movement against Israeli occupation and as a defender of Lebanon. Israel, however, views Hezbollah as a major security threat because of its weapons, military presence, and attacks against Israel. This creates a complicated situation for Lebanese sovereignty because the Lebanese government is expected to control its own territory, but Hezbollah has significant military influence in southern Lebanon.

A major turning point was the 2006 war between Israel and Hezbollah. The conflict lasted 33 days and caused major destruction and displacement. In its 2006 report, "Special Research Report No.6: Resolution 1701," the Security Council Report stated that the war left around 1,187 people dead in Lebanon and 160 in Israel, and displaced about one million Lebanese people and 300,000 Israelis. After the war, the United Nations Security Council adopted Resolution 1701 on 11 August 2006. This resolution called for a full cessation of hostilities, the withdrawal of Israeli forces from southern Lebanon, and the deployment of the Lebanese Armed Forces and UNIFIL in the south. It also authorized UNIFIL to increase its force strength to a maximum of 15,000 troops.

However, Resolution 1701 has not fully solved the issue. The resolution aimed to create stability south of the Litani River by limiting the presence of armed groups other than the Lebanese Armed Forces and UNIFIL. In practice, Israel continues to argue that Hezbollah's weapons and presence violate the resolution, while Lebanon continues to accuse Israel of violating Lebanese sovereignty, especially

through airspace violations and actions near disputed areas. Because of this, the Lebanon-Israel border remains unstable.

In the Palestinian Territories, the issue of sovereignty is mainly connected to the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and Gaza. These territories came under Israeli control after the 1967 Arab-Israeli War. Since then, Palestinians have sought recognition of their right to self-determination and statehood in these territories. Israel, on the other hand, argues that security concerns, historical claims, and political negotiations must be taken into account.

The West Bank is one of the most important areas in this dispute. It includes Palestinian cities and villages, Israeli military-controlled areas, and Israeli settlements. Israeli settlements are communities built for Israeli civilians in territory captured in 1967. Palestinians and much of the international community view these settlements as illegal because they are built on occupied territory. Israel disputes this interpretation and argues that the legal and historical status of the land is more complex.

The United Nations Security Council addressed this issue in Resolution 2334, adopted on 23 December 2016. The resolution stated that Israeli settlements in the occupied Palestinian territory, including East Jerusalem, have no legal validity and are a major obstacle to the two-state solution. It also called for Israel to immediately and completely stop all settlement activity.

East Jerusalem is another central issue. Palestinians want East Jerusalem to be the capital of a future Palestinian state, while Israel considers Jerusalem its capital. This makes Jerusalem one of the most difficult issues in any peace process. The status of Jerusalem is connected not only to politics and borders, but also to religion, identity, and access to holy sites.

Gaza is also part of the Palestinian Territories, but its situation is different from the West Bank. Israel withdrew its settlements and permanent ground forces from Gaza in 2005, but it still controls many aspects of Gaza's borders, airspace, and movement. Egypt also controls one border crossing. Hamas has controlled Gaza internally since 2007. This has created a situation where Gaza has limited sovereignty and faces severe restrictions, repeated wars, and humanitarian crises.

The humanitarian impact of the conflict is one of the reasons this issue remains urgent. According to OCHA, by May 2026, around 1,600 displacement sites across Gaza were hosting about 1.7 million

people, based on data collected between February and May 2026. OCHA also reported that the occupied Palestinian territory remains heavily fragmented, with people unable to move freely between Gaza and the West Bank and with movement also restricted within each area. In the West Bank, OCHA reported more than 870 settler attacks causing casualties or property damage since the beginning of 2026, affecting more than 220 communities and averaging about six attacks per day.

These disputes continue because the main parties have very different views of sovereignty and security. Lebanon argues that its sovereignty must be respected and that Israel should not control or violate Lebanese territory. Israel argues that Hezbollah's military presence threatens its security. Palestinians argue that they have the right to self-determination and statehood in the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and Gaza. Israel argues that any final agreement must address its security concerns and political claims.

The United Nations Security Council has passed several resolutions to reduce conflict and support political solutions, but implementation remains difficult. In Lebanon, Resolution 1701 has helped create a framework for stability, but violations and tensions continue. In the Palestinian Territories, Resolution 2334 clearly addresses settlements, but settlement activity, settler violence, movement restrictions, and political division continue to affect the possibility of a peaceful solution.

Overall, territorial sovereignty disputes in Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories remain a major threat to regional peace and security. They affect civilians through displacement, violence, restricted movement, damaged infrastructure, and humanitarian need. For the Security Council, the challenge is to find solutions that respect international law, protect civilians, address security concerns, and create conditions for long-term political peace.

4. Key Parties Involved and their Perspectives

a) International Organizations

- i) **United Nations Security Council:** The United Nations Security Council's stance is based on maintaining international peace and security, supporting international law, and encouraging political solutions. Through Resolution 1701, the Council has called for stability along the Lebanon-Israel border and the strengthening of Lebanese state authority in southern Lebanon. Through Resolution 2334, the Council has stated that

Israeli settlements in the occupied Palestinian territory, including East Jerusalem, have no legal validity and are an obstacle to peace.

- ii) **UNIFIL:** UNIFIL maintains a neutral stance and focuses on de-escalation in southern Lebanon. It does not decide final borders or take a political position on territorial claims, but it supports the implementation of Resolution 1701, monitors the Blue Line, reports violations, and encourages all parties to avoid actions that could increase tensions.

b) Major States and Authorities

- i) **Lebanon:** Lebanon argues that its territorial sovereignty must be fully respected, especially along its southern border with Israel. The Lebanese government claims that areas such as Shebaa Farms, Kfar Shouba Hills, and parts of Ghajar are connected to Lebanese sovereignty. Lebanon also accuses Israel of violating its sovereignty through military actions, airspace violations, and continued control over disputed areas.
- ii) **Israel:** Israel's position is mainly based on security concerns. Israel argues that Hezbollah's military presence in southern Lebanon and attacks from armed groups threaten Israeli civilians and national security. Regarding the Palestinian Territories, Israel argues that any final agreement must address security, borders, Jerusalem, and historical claims. Israel also disputes the view that all settlements are illegal under international law.
- iii) **Palestine / Palestinian Authority:** The Palestinian Authority argues that Palestinians have the right to self-determination and statehood in the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and Gaza. It views Israeli occupation, settlements, movement restrictions, and control over borders as barriers to Palestinian sovereignty. The Palestinian Authority generally supports a negotiated two-state solution, with East Jerusalem as the capital of a future Palestinian state.
- iv) **United States:** The United States generally supports Israel's right to security and often emphasizes the need to protect Israel from threats by armed groups. At the same time, the U.S. has historically supported negotiations toward a two-state solution between Israel and Palestine. Its stance usually focuses on diplomacy, security guarantees, and negotiated agreements rather than unilateral action.
- v) **Iran:** Iran's stance is strongly opposed to Israel and supportive of groups that describe themselves as resistance movements, including Hezbollah and Hamas. Iran argues that it supports Palestinian rights and resistance against Israeli occupation. Israel and many

Western states view Iran's position as destabilizing because it supports armed groups involved in this conflict.

- vi) **Egypt and Jordan:** Egypt and Jordan generally support Palestinian statehood and a negotiated political solution while also maintaining peace treaties with Israel. Egypt often supports ceasefire negotiations, humanitarian access to Gaza, and mediation between Israel and Palestinian groups. Jordan strongly supports Palestinian claims to East Jerusalem and emphasizes its custodial role over Muslim and Christian holy sites in the city.

c) **Political and Armed Groups**

- i) **Hezbollah:** Hezbollah presents itself as a resistance movement against Israel and argues that its weapons are necessary to defend Lebanon and oppose Israeli occupation of disputed areas. It supports armed resistance as a way to pressure Israel. Israel and several other countries view Hezbollah as a threat to regional security and to Lebanese state authority.
- ii) **Hamas:** Hamas rejects Israel's control over Palestinian territories and presents itself as part of Palestinian resistance. It argues that armed resistance is justified against Israeli occupation and does not accept Israel's sovereignty over land it views as Palestinian. Israel, the United States, the European Union, and others classify Hamas as a terrorist organization.

5. Questions to Consider

1. How can the United Nations Security Council help protect the territorial sovereignty of Lebanon while also addressing Israel's security concerns regarding Hezbollah and other armed groups?
2. What steps can be taken to reduce violations and tensions along the Blue Line between Lebanon and Israel?
3. How can Resolution 1701 be better implemented in southern Lebanon?
4. What role should UNIFIL play in preventing escalation between Lebanon, Israel, and Hezbollah?
5. How should the international community address disputed areas such as Shebaa Farms, Kfar Shouba Hills, and Ghajar?
6. How can the Security Council support Palestinian self-determination while also addressing Israel's stated security concerns?

7. What measures should be taken regarding Israeli settlements in the West Bank and East Jerusalem?
8. How can civilians in Gaza, the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and southern Lebanon be better protected?
9. What role should international law play in resolving territorial sovereignty disputes in Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories?
10. How can the Security Council encourage long-term political negotiations instead of repeated cycles of violence?

6. Suggested Research Resources

- a) Security Council Resolution 1701 (2006)

<https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/581053?v=pdf>

The core Lebanon resolution: cessation of hostilities, Israeli withdrawal, the Blue Line-Litani buffer zone, and UNIFIL's expansion to 15,000 troops.

- b) Security Council Resolution 2334 (2016)

<https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/853446?v=pdf>

The key settlements resolution: declares Israeli settlements illegal, demands they cease, and sets up quarterly reporting on implementation.

- c) ICJ Advisory Opinion on the Occupied Palestinian Territory (2024)

<https://www.icj-cij.org/node/204175>

The 2024 ruling that Israel's occupation is unlawful and settlements must stop. The strongest legal source on occupation and self-determination.

- d) OCHA - occupied Palestinian Territory

<https://www.ochaopt.org/>

Up-to-date humanitarian data: casualties, displacement, settler attacks, and movement restrictions.

e) UNIFIL - UN Interim Force in Lebanon

<https://unifil.unmissions.org/en/unifil-mandate>

The mission's mandate and the Blue Line, plus how violations of Resolution 1701 are monitored and reported.

f) Security Council Report

<https://www.securitycouncilreport.org/>

Monthly forecasts and background on Council dynamics; who supports or blocks what, useful for drafting realistic resolutions.

g) UNISPAL - The Question of Palestine

<https://www.un.org/unispal/>

The UN'S official document archive on Palestine, including the quarterly reports on Resolution 2334.

h) UN Meetings Coverage & Press Releases

<https://press.un.org/en>

Official records of Council sessions, with voting records and the statements each country delivered.

i) International Crisis Group

<https://www.crisisgroup.org/>

Independent analysis and concrete policy recommendations, helpful for shaping solution clauses.

j) UN News

<https://news.un.org/en/>

Accessible summaries and explainers to stay current in the weeks before the conference.

Finally, each delegate should also check their assigned country's foreign ministry website and its recent statements at the United Nations. The goal in committee is to represent the country's official position, not your own views.

7. Conclusion

Territorial sovereignty disputes in Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories remain among the most serious and complex issues facing the United Nations Security Council. In Lebanon, unresolved border questions, the presence of Hezbollah, Israeli security concerns, and the incomplete implementation of Resolution 1701 continue to create instability along the southern border. In the Palestinian Territories, disputes over the West Bank, East Jerusalem, Gaza, Israeli settlements, movement restrictions, and Palestinian self-determination continue to prevent a lasting political solution.

These issues are important because they affect not only governments and borders, but also the daily lives of civilians. Repeated violence, displacement, restricted movement, damaged infrastructure, and humanitarian crises show that territorial disputes have serious human consequences. They also increase the risk of wider regional conflict, especially when armed groups, neighboring states, and international actors become involved.

As member states, it is important to consider how the Security Council can balance international law, national sovereignty, security concerns, and civilian protection. A successful resolution should not only address immediate violence but also support long-term stability, accountability, and political dialogue. Moving forward, member states should focus on practical solutions that reduce tensions, protect civilians, and create conditions for a more sustainable peace.

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